Coming Home to the Father

Repentance is coming to our senses and coming home, and the Father runs to meet every sinner who turns back to him.

Main passage	Luke 15:11-24 (KJV)
Topic	Repentance
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: Sin promises freedom and leaves us starving	7 min
Teaching point 2: Repentance is coming to our senses and coming home	7 min
Teaching point 3: The Father runs to meet us	7 min
Discussion questions	7 min
Application	3 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Ask: "Have you ever been lost, really lost, as a child or as an adult? What did it feel like to be found?" Let one or two people tell their stories. Explain that Luke 15 is the "lost and found" chapter of the Bible: a lost sheep, a lost coin and a lost son.

Scripture (3 min)

Luke 15:11-24

11 And he said, A certain man had two sons: 12 And the younger of them said to his father, Father, give me the portion of goods that falleth to me. And he divided unto them his living. 13 And not many days after the younger son gathered all together, and took his journey into a far country, and there wasted his substance with riotous living. 14 And when he had spent all, there arose a mighty famine in that land; and he began to be in want. 15 And he went and joined himself to a citizen of that country; and he sent him into his fields to

feed swine. [16] And he would fain have filled his belly with the husks that the swine did eat: and no man gave unto him. [17] And when he came to himself, he said, How many hired servants of my father's have bread enough and to spare, and I perish with hunger! [18] I will arise and go to my father, and will say unto him, Father, I have sinned against heaven, and before thee, [19] And am no more worthy to be called thy son: make me as one of thy hired servants. [20] And he arose, and came to his father. But when he was yet a great way off, his father saw him, and had compassion, and ran, and fell on his neck, and kissed him. [21] And the son said unto him, Father, I have sinned against heaven, and in thy sight, and am no more worthy to be called thy son. [22] But the father said to his servants, Bring forth the best robe, and put it on him; and put a ring on his hand, and shoes on his feet: [23] And bring hither the fatted calf, and kill it; and let us eat, and be merry: [24] For this my son was dead, and is alive again; he was lost, and is found. And they began to be merry.

Read the passage aloud, perhaps with a narrator, the younger son and the father. Today's reading stops at verse 24; the story of the older brother (vv. 25-32) can be read at home.

Background (5 min)

Luke 15 begins with the setting: tax collectors and sinners were coming to hear Jesus, and the Pharisees grumbled, "This man receiveth sinners, and eateth with them" (15:2). Jesus answered with three parables. In each something is lost, searched for or longed for, found, and celebrated.

Asking for one's inheritance while the father was still alive was shocking; it was close to saying "I wish you were dead." Feeding pigs was the lowest job imaginable for a Jew, since pigs were unclean animals. Barnes notes that the younger son pictures the "publicans and sinners," and the older son the Pharisees and scribes.

Teaching point 1: Sin promises freedom and leaves us starving (7 min)

The younger son wanted his father's gifts without his father's presence. He found freedom, then famine. Sin always overpromises. By the end he was feeding pigs and wishing he could eat their food. Matthew Henry sums up the story in a few short sayings.

Supporting verses

Luke 15:11-16 (read from the Bible)

Isaiah 55:2: Wherefore do ye spend money for that which is not bread? and your labour for that which satisfieth not? hearken diligently unto me, and eat ye that which is good, and let your soul delight itself in fatness.

Romans 6:23: For the wages of sin is death; but the gift of God is eternal life through Jesus Christ our Lord.

> *"It is bad, and the beginning of worse, when men look upon God's gifts as debts."*
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Luke 15:11-32

> *"Shame, contempt, and distress are wedded to sin, and can never be divorced."*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Luke 15:15

Handout blanks (answers)

The son wanted his father's gifts but not his father's **presence**.

Sin promises freedom but leads to **famine (emptiness)**.

Teaching point 2: Repentance is coming to our senses and coming home (7 min)

"He came to himself" (v. 17). Sin is a kind of madness, and repentance is a return to sanity. The son saw his condition, remembered his father's goodness, decided to go back, and confessed honestly: "Father, I have sinned." Repentance is more than feeling sorry. It is a change of mind that turns our feet toward home.

Supporting verses

Luke 15:17-19: And when he came to himself, he said, How many hired servants of my father's have bread enough and to spare, and I perish with hunger! I will arise and go to my father, and will say unto him, Father, I have sinned against heaven, and before thee, And am no more worthy to be called thy son: make me as one of thy hired servants.

Psalm 51:3-4: For I acknowledge my transgressions: and my sin is ever before me. Against thee, thee only, have I sinned, and done this evil in thy sight: that thou mightest be justified when thou speakest, and be clear when thou judgest.

Acts 3:19: Repent ye therefore, and be converted, that your sins may be blotted out, when the times of refreshing shall come from the presence of the Lord;

> *"A state of sin is represented in the sacred writings as a course of folly and madness; and repentance is represented as a restoration to sound sense."*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Luke 15:17

Handout blanks (answers)

When he came to **himself**, he said, "I will arise and go to my father."

Repentance is a change of mind that **turns** us toward God.

Teaching point 3: The Father runs to meet us (7 min)

The most surprising person in the story is the father. He sees his son "a great way off," runs, hugs and kisses him, and interrupts his confession with a robe, a ring, shoes and a feast. That is Jesus' picture of God. We do not have to clean ourselves up before coming home. The Father is already watching the road.

Supporting verses

Luke 15:20-24 (read from the Bible)

Luke 15:7: I say unto you, that likewise joy shall be in heaven over one sinner that repenteth, more than over ninety and nine just persons, which need no repentance.

Psalm 103:13: Like as a father pitieth his children, so the LORD pitieth them that fear him.

> *“when but the face is turned homeward, though as yet far, far away, our Father recognizes His own child in us, and bounds to meet us”*
> — David Brown, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Luke 15:20

> *“The father thus showed his great tenderness towards him, and his great affection for him.”*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Luke 15:20

Handout blanks (answers)

When he was yet a great way off, his father **ran** and fell on his neck.

This my son was dead, and is **alive** again.

Discussion questions (7 min)

1. What do you think the younger son was really looking for when he left?

Independence, pleasure, freedom from his father's authority. He wanted the gifts without the giver.

2. What does "he came to himself" tell us about sin and about repentance?

Sin distorts our thinking; repentance is waking up to reality about ourselves and about God.

3. Why do you think the father ran? (In that culture, older men did not run.)

His love was greater than his dignity; Jesus shows God eager to welcome sinners home.

4. Is there anyone you know who is "a great way off" from God? How can we reflect the Father's welcome to them?

Answers will vary; pray for them, keep the door open, avoid the older brother's resentment.

Application (3 min)

Take time this week to "come to yourself." Ask God to show you any area where you have wandered from him, and confess it honestly. Then thank him that he runs to meet you. If someone you love is far from God, pray for them by name every day.

Closing prayer (2 min)

Father, like the son in the far country, we have wandered and wasted your gifts. Thank you that you watch the road for us and run to meet us when we turn toward home. Bring us to our senses where we have strayed. Clothe us in your grace, and teach us to welcome others as you have welcomed us. In Jesus' name, Amen.

Sources quoted

Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Luke 15:11-32

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Luke 15:15

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Luke 15:17

David Brown, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Luke 15:20

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Luke 15:20

Every quotation was checked word for word against the library text it cites. All sources are in the public domain.